and heavily implemented the 27 per cent quota. The September 2022 cutoff marks the date when the government cited mounting legal challenges to issue an interim framework: recruitments thereafter were only processed for 87 per cent of the seats, keeping the extra 13 per cent provisionally frozen. That last quantum now stands cancelled. Politically, that's emerged as a major challenge to the current CM, who has time and again reiterated that he is committed to the cause of more reservation for OBCs. Yadav had even convened an all-party meet where a unanimous resolution was passed supporting it.

OBCs, as a political force, have only gone from strength to strength in the state in the past three decades. The BJP has ruled MP since 2003 except for the 15-month Kamal Nath interregnum. All its CMs in this period have hailed from prominent OBC communities: Uma Bharti, Babulal Gaur, Shivraj; now, Yadav too is patently an outcome of that recruitment process, so to speak. The Congress was slower in responding to this imperative: its past leadership visibly ticked the privileged caste box. It's only in 2023, roughly coterminous with the caste turn in Rahul Gandhi's politics, that an OBC face—Jitendra Patwari—arrived at the state unit's top.

A Math Puzzle

There are those who argue that understanding 'OBCs' as a single, homogenous bloc is flawed. Kamal Nath government's March 2019 ordinance caused no discernible swing in OBC votes in the Lok Sabha election a month later: the Congress got one seat in the state. The ordinance became law in August, but with similar results: in 2023, the wave created by Ladli Behna overrode all segmentation; in the 2024 LS election, the Congress drew a blank.

That may or may not be the yardstick to measure the electoral weight of OBCs, and Yadav may not want to risk it. The narrative going around isn't helpful. "The state government did not submit any data related to OBCs in the court," says Rameshwar Singh Thakur, the senior advocate who represented the OBC group. "Obviously, there would be inadequate data to support the case. The Congress government had submitted data from the 2011 Census, where OBCs stood at 50.09 per cent of the population."

Thakur, a veteran of the legal battle, says the BJP was never serious about enhancing quotas. "Else, it would have been implementing 27 per cent. It was possible. There was no HC or SC stay," he argues. The state, he says, also gave multiple affidavits saying 14 per cent should be followed. He also questions the "dual policy" for OBCs and EWS. Counting the 10 per cent for the latter, he says, "the total reservation in MP stands at 60 per cent, which breaches 50 per cent. This is allowed by the SC. Why can't 50 per cent then be breached for OBCs?" he quips. "Only 1.7 per cent of MP would qualify as EWS under its present definition. Why does this group have 10 per cent reservation?"

Making it trickier politically, states adjacent to MP have higher OBC quota percentages: Uttar Pradesh 27 (via a legislation brought in soon after *Indira Sahwney* 1992), Rajasthan 21, Maharashtra 19 for education and jobs and up to 27 in local body polls, Gujarat 27. Chhattisgarh, like MP, had 14—now hiked to 27 per cent, with no legal setback till now. MP has 53 castes designated as OBC. It's estimated that Kurmis, at 10-12 per cent, are the largest group, followed by the Kaachis and Lodhis.

"The SLP is welcome, but one doesn't see the BJP or Opposition doing much for the cause. I think social organisations will have to take up the matter," says a backward caste representative. The Pichhda Varg Mahasabha, an umbrella group of OBC groups, and the PDA (Pichhda Dalit Adivasi), a group formed by Damodar Yadav, a vocal OBC leader from North MP, are planning an agitation. Expect the stakes, and the pitch, to rise through census year 2027 and election year 2028. ■

—with Ajay Sukumaran

THE MAP OF MANDAL 3.0

Since 2015, nine states have attempted to breach the 50% ceiling—almost all in vain



- In October, the high courts at Madhya Pradesh and Karnataka strike down legislations that pushed caste quotas beyond 50%
- Maharashtra, Telangana, Andhra, Rajasthan, Haryana, Bihar have all gone down this route before. Only Chhattisgarh law is active
- CMs Mohan Yadav in MP and D.K. Shivakumar (above) in Karnataka in a political bind—not ensuring higher quotas will anger key blocs
- In early 2027, the Census begins India's first official caste count since 1931. That may intensify quota calls based on demographics

IN MP, ALL BJP CHIEF MINISTERS SINCE 2003 HAVE BEEN OBC FACES. NOW, CONGRESS, CASTE GROUPS SAY IT LET A PRO-OBC LAW LAPSE